Third System
AI Presence Index

How Often, and How Evenly

AIAS™ 2.0 measures two separate things about a brand in AI answers. Both held for five months, and neither can stand in for the other.

November 2026 · Pablo Ulpiano González Castro

AIAS™ 2.0 synthesis

When someone asks an AI assistant which brand to buy, the brands it names become the shortlist. Third System™ measures that shortlist as AI Availability. Until now the measure had one part, Presence: how often AI models name a brand. AIAS™ 2.0 adds a second, Consistency: whether the models agree in naming it. Across five categories, 112 brands and three waves from May to November 2026, the two parts stayed separate and each kept its brand order for five months. Brand teams now get two scores, read side by side.

Consistency does not follow Presence: the two were nearly unrelated in May, June and November (0.07, 0.08 and 0.19). Both kept their brand order from June to November (0.95 and 0.65), Consistency by more than the questions alone explain. No single combined number passed the tests set for it, so the score is reported as a pair.

Four findings and one rule. First, Consistency is a measure of its own: a brand's Consistency says little about its Presence, and changes in one say nothing about changes in the other. Second, both scores are stable properties of a brand: Presence kept its order almost perfectly over five months, and Consistency kept its order well beyond what the structure of the questions produces. Third, the agreement measure that works is the second one built: the first moved with how often a brand is named, so it was replaced. Fourth, folding the two into one number does not work: every combined score tested either repeated Presence or broke one of the tests. The rule: Consistency is rated only for brands the six models name at least six times, which in each wave is about half the brands.

For brand teams this separates two questions that are easy to read as one. Presence asks how often AI assistants name you. Consistency asks whether they agree in doing so. A brand named by some models and not others depends on which assistant a buyer happens to use; a brand named evenly does not. Because the two scores move independently, improving one says nothing about the other, and each needs tracking.

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What we measured

The data are the five categories the program has tracked since May 2026: audiophile headphones, skincare, cosmetics, automotive and premium spirits, 112 brands in all. The same six AI models (two each from Anthropic, OpenAI and Google) answered the same questions three times (852 answers per wave): in late May, in June, and on November 9, 152 days later. Each brand was asked about directly (does the model know it?) and indirectly (does the model name it when asked about the category?).

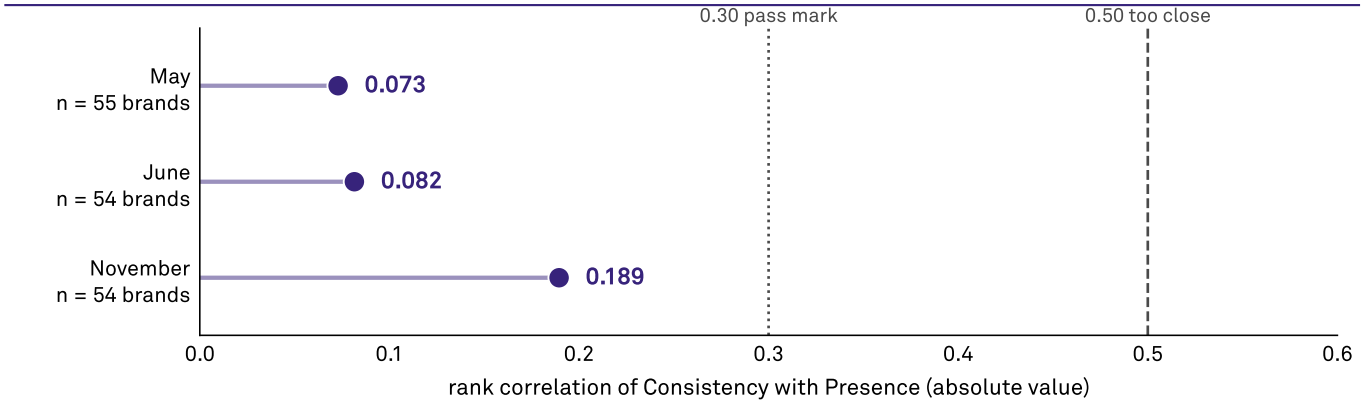
Presence combines the two into a score from 0 to 100. Consistency compares the six models: it is 100 when every model names a brand equally often across the same questions, and falls toward 0 as some models name it and others do not. Before the November answers were scored, the synthesis registered publicly which tests it would rely on and how its headline would read for every possible result.

FINDING 01

Consistency is a measure of its own

Link between the two scores, by wave

Rank correlation of Consistency with Presence within each category (0 = unrelated)



Source: AIAS 2.0 synthesis data; Methodology v1.9 (SSRN 7685126) | AIAS 2.0 synthesis, Third System

How closely each brand's Consistency tracks its Presence, within categories, in each of the three waves. All three readings sit well below the 0.30 pass mark (0.073 in May, 0.082 in June, 0.189 in November): knowing a brand's Presence says little about its Consistency.

Within each category, brands were ranked on both scores and the two rankings compared. The link was 0.07 in May, 0.08 in June and 0.19 in November, the wave that served as the test, against a pass mark of 0.30. Changes were unrelated too: how far a brand's Consistency moved between June and November had nothing to do with how far its Presence moved (0.03, 80 brands). A factor that shapes Presence, how much of a brand's naming comes from its cultural identity rather than its category, has no effect on Consistency (-0.01, 53 brands). Two brands with the same Presence can sit far apart on Consistency.

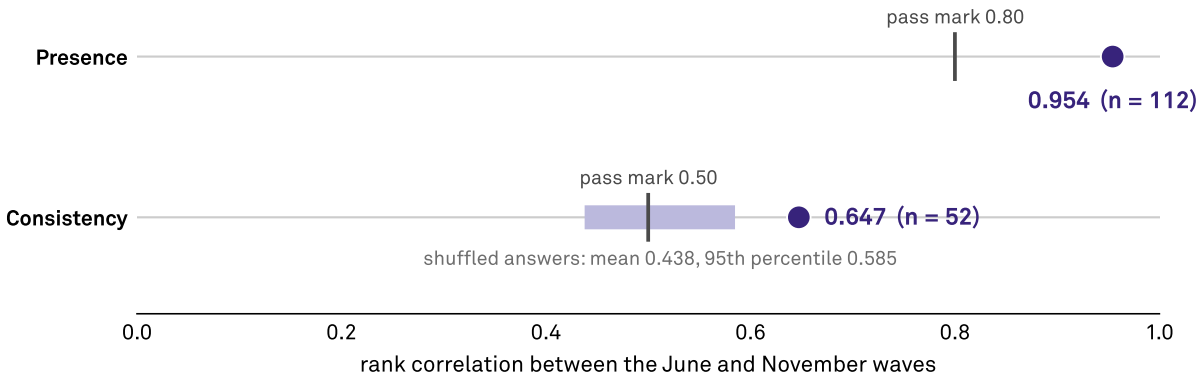
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FINDING 02

Both scores held for five months

Brand order kept from June to November

Rank correlation between the two waves, with the range produced by shuffled answers



Source: AIAS 2.0 synthesis data; v0.41 (SSRN 7685100); v1.9 | AIAS 2.0 synthesis, Third System

How well each score kept its brand order from June to November. Presence (0.954, 112 brands) is far above its pass mark. Consistency (0.647, 52 brands) is above its pass mark and above the 0.585 that shuffled answers reach in 95 of 100 tries, so its stability is not only a product of the questions.

From June to November, Presence kept its brand order at 0.95 across all 112 brands, and the naming rate within every category at 0.93 or more. Consistency kept its order at 0.65 across the 52 brands rated in both waves, against a pass mark of 0.50. Any measure of agreement gets some stability from the questions themselves: with each model's answers shuffled within each question, the same comparison averages 0.44, and 95 of 100 tries stay below 0.59. Consistency clears that line, so the stability belongs to the brands, not only to the questions. A test for decay between the three-week and five-month comparisons found none.

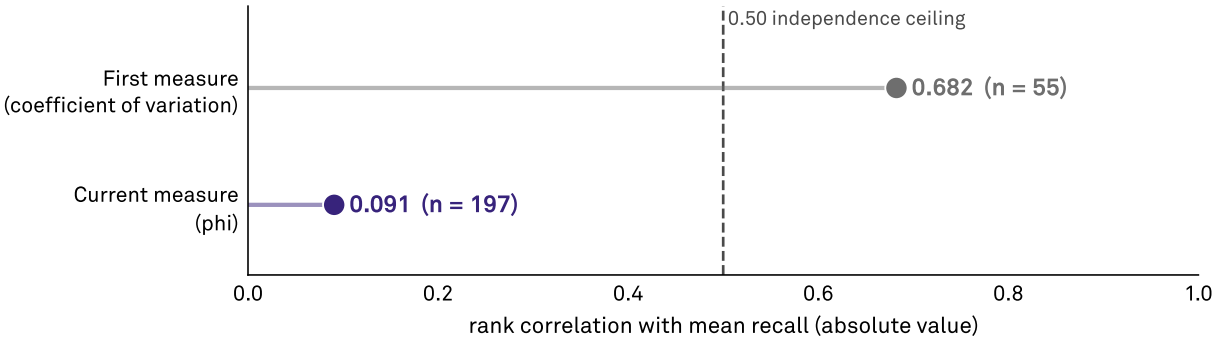
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FINDING 03

The first agreement measure failed; the second did not

How much each agreement measure moves with naming frequency

Rank correlation with mean recall on the same brands (0 = independent)



Source: Methodology v1.8 (SSRN 6963359); v1.7 (SSRN 6878818) | AIAS 2.0 synthesis, Third System

How much each agreement measure moves with how often a brand is named. The first measure tracked naming frequency (0.682, 55 brands) and was replaced; the current measure does not (0.091, 197 brands).

The program's first agreement measure, built in June, compared how much the models' counts varied with their average. Counts that can only run from zero to six make that ratio follow the average, so the measure moved with how often a brand is named (0.68 on the same data), and a registered test rejected it. Its replacement compares the models' spread with the spread expected from chance at the same naming rate. It is unrelated to naming frequency (0.09) and can be computed for every brand named at least once (84 of 84, against 55).

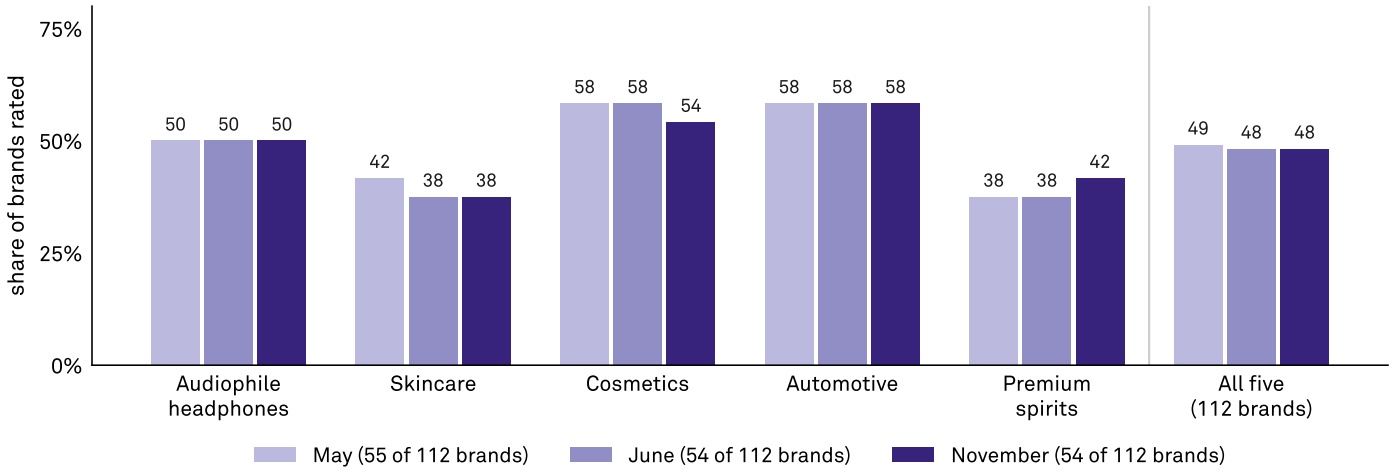
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FINDING 04

Rated only where there is evidence

Share of brands named often enough to rate, by category and wave

Rated = the six models together name the brand at least six times out of 36



Source: AIAS 2.0 synthesis data; v1.9 rating rule | AIAS 2.0 synthesis, Third System

The share of brands the six models name at least six times, and so can be rated for Consistency, by category and wave. In each wave 55, 54 and 54 of the 112 brands are rated; by category the share runs from 38% to 58%.

A brand named once or twice looks consistent by default, because a single mention cannot show disagreement. Averaged with Presence, an unrated score would have given brands named once 58 points against 30 for brands never named, a premium earned by chance. Rating Consistency only from six mentions removes it. The cost is coverage: 55, 54 and 54 of 112 brands were rated in May, June and November, between 38% and 58% by category. A brand below the line is shown as not rated, not as inconsistent.

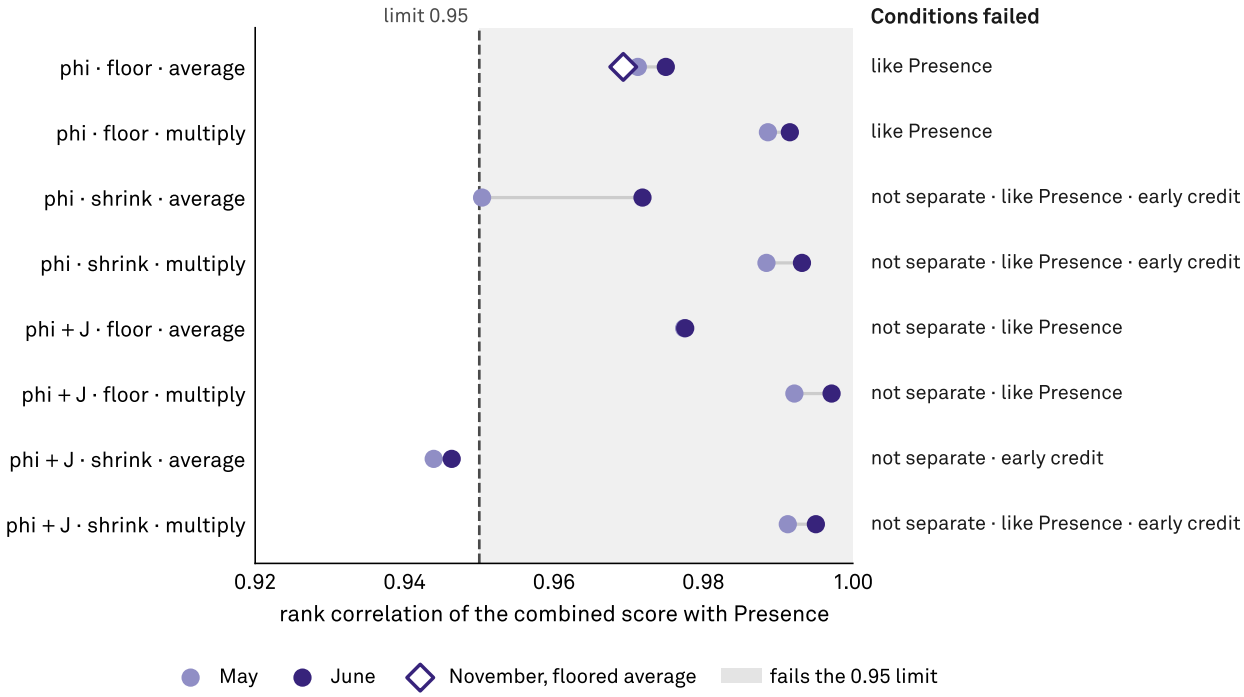
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FINDING 05

Two numbers, not one

Eight combined scores against the tests set for them

How closely each candidate ranks brands like Presence, May and June, and the condition it failed



Source: Methodology v1.9 calibration record | AIAS 2.0 synthesis, Third System

The eight combined scores fixed before the November data, tested on the May and June data. Every one fails at least one of the three tests, and seven of the eight rank brands too much like Presence (the shaded zone). The four that use the six-mention rule rank brands at 0.971 to 0.997 with Presence; in November the plain average of the two still stood at 0.969.

Before the November data were scored, eight combined scores were fixed and tested on the May and June data against three conditions: keep Consistency separate, rank brands differently from Presence, and give no extra credit for a mention or two. Each failed at least one. The ones that kept Consistency separate ranked brands at 0.97 to 0.99 with Presence, against a limit of 0.95, because Presence runs across the whole scale while rated Consistency sits mostly between 60 and 100. In November a plain average of the two still matched Presence at 0.97. A single 0-100 score remains the goal; with two parts it would be Presence under another name.

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Limitations

Everything here applies to one panel of six models, now retiring, which answered without web search; scores from a new panel must be recalibrated before they are compared with these. Five categories and 112 brands limit the precision of every figure, and the Consistency checks rest on 52 to 54 rated brands. About half the brands are named too rarely to rate, so Consistency describes the regularly named part of each category.

Part of Consistency's stability comes from the questions themselves; the comparison with shuffled answers measures that share but does not remove it. Questions were in English. Neither score has yet been tested against what buyers do: stable, separate scores are what a useful measure needs, not proof that it predicts sales.

What’s next

The same 112 brands are being measured this month on the newest AI models, with web search off and on, so that both scores can be recalibrated for the panel the program uses from now on. A separate study, registered before any of its data were looked at, tests whether Presence and Consistency anticipate changes in how often people search for a brand.

The third part of AI Availability, Ranking (where a brand appears in an AI answer's list), opens AIAS 3.0. When it is measured, the question of one combined number reopens under the same tests and the same rule.

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The five propositions, scored

Each proposition is the managerial reading of a locked result, scored for brand teams rather than reviewers.

#	Proposition	Status
P1	A brand's Consistency carries information its Presence does not.	**SUPPORTED — 0.07, 0.08 and 0.19 with Presence in May, June and November; 0.03 between their changes**
P2	Presence and Consistency keep their brand order from June to November.	**SUPPORTED — 0.95 for Presence (112 brands); 0.65 for Consistency (52 brands), above shuffled answers**
P3	Consistency can be measured without moving with how often a brand is named.	**SUPPORTED — first measure 0.68 with naming frequency; current measure 0.09**
P4	Consistency is rated only for brands named at least six times.	*LOCKED RULE — fixed before November; 48 to 49% of brands rated in each wave*
P5	The AI Availability Score reports Presence and Consistency separately.	*DECIDED — 8 of 8 pre-set combined scores failed; an average of the two still matched Presence at 0.97 in November*

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AI assistants now sit between many buyers and the brands they consider. Knowing how often they name a brand was the first step. Knowing whether they agree is the second, and it turns out to be a different fact about the brand, stable enough to track. Read together, the two scores show not only whether a brand is in the AI shortlist, but how dependably.

About the Third System

The Third System describes a shift in how consumers make decisions: instead of browsing and comparing options directly, many now rely on AI systems to generate recommendations. In this environment, brands compete not only for human attention but for inclusion within AI-generated outputs. This creates a new competitive layer where visibility is determined by how AI systems interpret and surface brands.

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Third System™ (research entity)

Methodology

This report presents findings from Third System's AI Availability research program. The AI Availability Score (AIAS) is an early-stage measurement framework introduced in Tri-System Brand Growth (Gonzalez Castro, 2026). Findings should be used directionally. Construct validity — the correlation between AI Availability and consumer behavior — has not yet been established and is the subject of Phase 3 of the research program. Methodology is published in full and versioned at thirdsystem.ai/methodology (current: Presence v1.6; Consistency v1.8, v1.9). Registry construction is curated and reflects the framework's view of each category's competitive set; revisions are documented in the methodology log.

Citation

González Castro, P. U. (2026). ***Presence and Consistency: A Two-Component Measurement of AI Availability (The AIAS™ 2.0 Synthesis)***. Third System (SSRN pending). thirdsystem.ai/methodology

Underlying datasets

Synthesis data: osf.io/ec6wh/aias_2_0/aias_2_0_synthesis_data.json

Per-brand profiles: osf.io/ec6wh/aias_2_0/aias_2_0_profiles.csv

Stage 2 verdicts: osf.io/ec6wh/methodology/v1_9/v1_9_verdicts.json (and v0.41 verdicts, osf.io/ec6wh/v41)

Pre-registration: synthesis outline tag aias-2-0-outline-locked; v1.9-prereg-r1; v0.41-prereg-r1

Methodology log: AIAS 2.0 synthesis (November 2026).

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